How do people feel about Facebook? Coding sentiment by hand

Research methods · October 2026 · Sheryl Winston Smith

The data. These are real tweets that mention Facebook, all posted within 30 minutes on 1 October 2015. That day Facebook announced profile videos, and the startup Peeple (a "Yelp for people") was in the news. Spelling and grammar are as the authors wrote them. A " / " marks a line break in the original tweet.

Your task

1. Read each tweet and ask one question: what does the writer feel about Facebook (the company, the app, or its features)?

2. Write one label: Positive, Negative, or Neutral. Use Neutral when the tweet gives no opinion about Facebook. That includes tweets that are emotional about something else, ads, and plain questions or facts.

3. Rate how confident you are: 1 = a guess, 2 = fairly sure, 3 = certain.

4. Write down the word or words that drove your decision.

5. Work alone first (about 10 minutes). Then compare with a neighbour and note where you disagree.

Worked examples

W1 "I love that Facebook lets us see our memories so I can know that it's been 5 yrs of being best friends w/ @JenniferATenut & @morriskatelyn!"
Label: Positive (confidence 3). The writer loves a Facebook feature (memories). The feeling is aimed directly at Facebook. Clue words: "I love that Facebook lets us".

W2 "Today, 3 years ago, the Angels unfortunately didn't make the playoffs. Facebook reminded me by showing my memories."
Label: Neutral (confidence 2). The tweet is sad, but the sadness is about a baseball team missing the playoffs. Facebook only delivered the reminder. Ask what the feeling is about, not just whether there is a feeling. Clue words: "unfortunately" (aimed at the Angels).

Your turn

ID	Tweet	Label (+ / 0 / −)	Conf. (1–3)	Clue words
H1	Deleted Facebook app from phone. It's amazing how much battery I have left at end of day.			
H2	Facebook's new layout changes sound so stupid. 7 second video to replace profile pictures? Temporary profile pictures? Why?			
H3	Deactivating Facebook is still one of the best choices I've ever made. Why fill your soul with such negativity? On a daily basis, even!			
H4	Esse facebook ta me irritando			
H5	300 Facebook fan page likes for $3 [link removed]			

H6	Not sure I like the sound of Twitter's plan to remove the 140 character limit. It will turn into Facebook and that's not good!			
H7	I cannot believe Im activelly enjoying a Facebook game			
H8	Do you still use Facebook ? #RNAMERCY			

Discuss

1. Which tweet was hardest to label, and why? Did you and your neighbour disagree on any?

2. Look at your clue words. Were they always positive or negative words ("love", "stupid")? Or did you rely on context?

3. A simple computer method counts positive and negative words. On which of these tweets would it agree with you, and on which would it go wrong?

4. If a client asked "How do people feel about Facebook today?", which of these tweets would you leave out of your sample?